

Security concessions will shield US trade talks

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Security concessions will shield US trade talks from political spillover

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Renewed pressure from Washington will push President Claudia Sheinbaum to offer targeted concessions to prevent politically sensitive security disputes from spilling into ongoing trade negotiations.

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Sheinbaum successfully rallied Morena governors and legislators to oppose the unilateral return of Sinaloa Governor Ruben Rocha (who is facing US criminal charges), strengthening her authority and demonstrating support for her approach to handling the US relationship.

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While any further moves against Rocha would only temporarily ease US pressure, Mexico does stand to benefit from the collapse in US-Canada trade talks, as President Donald Trump's administration is likely searching for a trade win that a US-Mexico deal could deliver.

Handling of Rocha's return will protect recent progress in bilateral talks. Rocha resumed the governorship on 21 August without consulting Sheinbaum. His return invited renewed pressure from Washington as Sheinbaum was trying to demonstrate progress to the US on security issues. It also undermined Morena's effort to signal that its new leadership would distance itself from compromised figures and questionable political networks ahead of the 2027 midterms.

The administration quickly distanced itself from Rocha's decision, and Sheinbaum publicly criticized his return. Morena's legislative leaders and 23 governors from the ruling coalition backed the president, prompting Rocha to request another indefinite leave. The episode ultimately strengthened Sheinbaum's position. Rather than exposing a lasting split within Morena, Rocha's challenge prompted the party to close ranks behind her handling of rising US security pressure. Sheinbaum will try to maintain this approach while avoiding any public rift with former president Andres Manuel Lopez Obrador.

Security cooperation has advanced despite political pressure from the US. Operational cooperation has continued to deepen even as Washington raises pressure on politically sensitive targets. The Treasury Department and Mexico's Financial Intelligence Unit (UIF) recently coordinated sanctions against more than 50 individuals and entities linked to the financial and commercial networks of the Jalisco New Generation Cartel (CJNG). US authorities have also intensified enforcement against firearms networks supplying Mexican criminal organizations, including recent prosecutions involving thousands of weapons and firearm components bound for Mexico.

With US support, Mexico also secured the return from Argentina of former rear admiral Fernando Farias to face charges tied to a fuel-smuggling network involving naval and customs officials. Those advances have continued amid mounting political pressure, including an announcement by Andres Lopez Beltran (son of Lopez Obrador) that the US revoked his visa (see: Sheinbaum's de-escalation options narrow as Washington targets Lopez Obrador's son , 14 August 2026). Sheinbaum's response has been to deepen cooperation where interests overlap and emphasize the benefits of sustained collaboration.

Sheinbaum will work to keep security and trade on separate tracks. Her priority will be to prevent security disputes from creating another obstacle in trade negotiations with Washington. Trade and security remain formally separate, and Mexico still benefits from preferential access to the US market (see: Mutual interests keep trade and security on separate tracks for now , 13 May 2026). However, unilateral US security actions, demands involving politically prominent figures, or a perception in Washington that Mexico is protecting officials accused of cartel ties could worsen the political environment around trade talks.

Sheinbaum will therefore be willing to make targeted concessions on financial investigations, high-value criminal cases, and operational coordination to show progress. Her red lines will remain direct US operations in Mexico and any targeting of Lopez Obrador.

The breakdown in US-Canada talks could benefit Mexico on trade. The collapse of negotiations strengthens Washington's incentives to reach a deal with Mexico in 2026. Trump is still searching for an economic win that now looks not to be forthcoming from Ottawa, and Washington may now see a bilateral deal with Mexico as a means of pressuring Ottawa into one as well. This would replicate a strategy from US-Mexico-Canada Agreement (USMCA) negotiations in 2018. Moreover, the terms of the negotiation with Ottawa—featuring mooted reductions in auto and metals tariffs—give US and Mexico negotiators a target for which to aim. Security, however, will remain a less predictable political issue that could impede trade talks if not managed carefully.

Action against Rocha would remove one risk, not broader US pressure. Keeping Rocha out of office, and potentially advancing domestic action against him, would remove a highly visible irritant before the next phase of trade negotiations. That would not mean security concessions are part of a trade bargain. Rather, Sheinbaum's objective is to prevent an unrelated political confrontation from opening another front that could disrupt negotiations.

Targeting Rocha would therefore ease pressure only temporarily. US agencies are increasingly focused on broader political-criminal networks, while cooperating witnesses, financial investigations, visa restrictions, and sanctions grant Washington additional opportunities to scrutinize other officials. The status quo around Rocha is no longer sustainable, especially as Mexican investigators draw on new information from recent arrests. Sheinbaum will have to allow greater scrutiny of Morena-linked figures than the party would otherwise accept. Her ability to manage that process without triggering a broader intra-party rupture will be central to preserving both control over Morena and stability in the bilateral relationship.

Matias Gomez Leautaud

Analyst, Mexico

gomezleautaud.ne@eurasiagroup.net

Noah Daponte-Smith

Senior Analyst, United States

daponte-smith@eurasiagroup.net

Antonio Ortiz-Mena

Consultant, Latin America

ortiz.ne@eurasiagroup.net

Andrea Villegas

Researcher, Latin America

villegas.ne@eurasiagroup.net

EG Mexico

mexico@eurasiagroup.net

EG United States

unitedstates@eurasiagroup.net

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